



REVITAL PRODUCTIONS

Technology Stack & Future-Proof Growth Plan

The complete technology stack for Revital Productions, structured as a growth plan — which tools to use at each stage from a 3-person team today to 50+ employees.

Built in Layers, Never Rip & Replace

This document outlines the complete technology stack for Revital Productions — an AV/production/marketing agency based in Louisiana. It is structured as a future-proof growth plan, showing exactly which tools to use at each stage of growth from a 3-person team today to 50+ employees in the future. Every tool recommendation is chosen to avoid migration pain — the goal is to add layers, never rip and replace.

Core Architecture Principle: Build in layers. Each tool owns one function. Stripe processes payments forever. QuickBooks records accounting forever. HR and project tools get added as triggers are hit — never before they're needed, never after you've outgrown them.

Layer 1 — Accounting & Books: QuickBooks Online

QuickBooks is the permanent accounting foundation. It never gets replaced — only upgraded. Every CPA in Louisiana knows it, every tool in your stack connects to it, and it scales from \$0/month free today to full enterprise accounting at \$500K+ revenue.

PLAN	COST	WHEN TO USE	KEY FEATURES
Free	\$0/mo	Right now	1 bank account, 2 invoices/mo, basic P&L
Simple Start	\$38/mo	3+ clients	Unlimited invoices, Stripe sync, 1099s
Essentials	\$75/mo	5+ employees	Multi-user, bill tracking, time tracking
Plus	\$115/mo	\$500K+ revenue	Project profitability, class tracking, 5 users
Advanced	\$340/mo	\$1M+ revenue	Full analytics, payroll bundle, AI features

Note: QuickBooks raised prices in August 2026. If you sign up for a paid plan, skip the free trial to get 50% off for the first 3 months.

Stripe & FreshBooks

Stripe — Permanent Infrastructure

Stripe is already integrated into your proposal calculator and never gets phased out. It is the payment layer that every other tool reads from. QuickBooks syncs from it. FreshBooks marks invoices paid from it. ClickUp tracks status from it.

STAGE	STRIPE FEATURE	PURPOSE
Now	Payment Links	Client pays from proposal PDF
5+ clients	Recurring billing	Auto-charge monthly retainers
10+ clients	Stripe Invoicing	One-off project billing
\$500K+	Revenue Recognition	Deferred revenue accounting
\$1M+	Stripe Connect	Marketplace or sub-account features

Transaction fee: 2.9% + \$0.30 per card transaction. ACH bank transfers are cheaper at 0.8% capped at \$5. Encourage clients to pay via ACH for large invoices to reduce fees.

FreshBooks — Client Invoicing

Add FreshBooks when you have 5+ active clients on mixed billing arrangements (retainers + one-off projects). FreshBooks handles retainer billing natively — set up a retainer with deposit, log time against it, track unused balance. Connects directly to both Stripe and QuickBooks.

PLAN	COST	ACTIVE CLIENTS	KEY FEATURE
Lite	\$17/mo	Up to 5	Unlimited invoices, expense tracking
Plus	\$30/mo	Up to 50	Recurring billing, time tracking, retainers
Premium	\$55/mo	Unlimited	Project profitability, team members

The Most Important Layer to Plan Ahead

The tools change as you grow — but each transition is natural and well-defined. You add the next tool when you hit the trigger, never before.

Phase 1 — Contractors Only (Right Now)

QuickBooks handles everything. Track contractor payments, collect W-9s, generate and e-file 1099-NEC forms at year end. No additional tool needed.

- 1099-NEC threshold: \$600+ per contractor in 2025, increases to \$2,000 in 2026
- File by February 2 each year — no extensions
- QuickBooks e-files directly to the IRS — no third-party tool needed

Phase 2 — First W2 Employee (Gusto)

Add Gusto the week before your first W2 hire starts. Forbes Advisor 2026 rates Gusto 4.8 stars as the best HR software for integrated payroll and HR for growing businesses up to ~500 employees. Set it up before day one so payroll is ready immediately.

PLAN	BASE COST	PER PERSON	KEY FEATURES
Simple	\$40/mo	+\$6/person	Full payroll, W2s, 1099s, basic onboarding
Plus	\$60/mo	+\$9/person	HR tools, PTO tracking, performance reviews
Premium	\$135/mo	+\$16.50/person	Dedicated support, HR advisors, compliance alerts

Gusto connects natively to QuickBooks — payroll entries sync automatically, no manual data entry.

Phase 3 — Growing Team (BambooHR)

Add BambooHR alongside Gusto when you have 10+ employees or hire your first dedicated People Ops or HR team member. BambooHR is the best pure HRIS for companies that already have payroll handled. Gusto stays for payroll — BambooHR handles the employee lifecycle.

WHAT BAMBOOHR ADDS	WHY IT MATTERS
Employee records & org chart	Single source of truth for all people data
Onboarding workflows	New hire is productive on Day 1 not Day 5
Performance review cycles	Structured feedback at scale
Time off tracking & approvals	Replaces spreadsheet vacation tracking
Offboarding checklists	Consistent exits, reduces compliance risk
Employee self-service portal	Staff manage own info — saves HR admin hours

Cost: ~\$6-9/person/month. Connects to Gusto for payroll sync.

Phase 4 — Scaling Fast (Rippling)

Rippling is the only HR platform that natively unifies HR, IT, and payroll in a single system. When you hit 30-50 employees, Rippling replaces both Gusto and BambooHR. Onboard a new hire, provision their laptop, enroll in benefits, and set up their email — all from one action.

- Trigger to switch: 30-50 employees or when IT device management becomes a burden
- Cost: Custom pricing, typically \$20-30/person/month
- Connects to QuickBooks/Xero for payroll accounting sync
- Supports 100+ countries if you ever hire internationally

Productive (AV / Production Specific)

Productive is the default for \$1M-\$15M agencies in 2026. For an AV/production/marketing agency it solves the specific problem of knowing which video shoots made money, which retainers are profitable, and what your true cost per hour is per team member. Posts to QuickBooks cleanly.

WHAT PRODUCTIVE TRACKS	WHY IT MATTERS FOR AV/PRODUCTION
True cost per project	Know if each video shoot was profitable before invoicing
Billable rate by role	Director vs. editor vs. PA — different rates tracked separately
Retainer utilization	See which marketing retainers are over/under delivering
Resource planning	Book crew and equipment across shoots without conflicts
Budget vs. actuals	Compare estimated vs. real cost per campaign
Client profitability	Rank clients by margin — know who to fire and who to grow

Cost: \$24-32/user/month. Add when revenue hits \$500K. Below that threshold, a Google Sheet per project covers the basics at no cost.

GROWTH TIMELINE

Full Stack by Stage

Today — 3 people, contractors only

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
QuickBooks Free	\$0/mo	Accounting, expense tracking, basic P&L
Stripe Payment Links	\$0 + 2.9%	Client payments via proposal calculator
ClickUp	Already active	Invoice tracking, project management, CRM

3+ Clients — revenue growing, active retainers

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
QuickBooks Simple Start	\$38/mo	Unlimited invoices, Stripe sync, 1099s
FreshBooks Lite	\$17/mo	Client-facing invoices, retainer tracking
Stripe	Keep	Payment processing — permanent

First W2 Hire — first full-time employee joins

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Gusto Simple	\$40 + \$6/person	Full payroll, benefits, W2s, onboarding
QuickBooks Simple Start	Keep	Payroll syncs from Gusto automatically
FreshBooks	Keep	Client billing

Full Stack by Stage

5-10 Employees — team growing, HR needs increase

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Gusto Plus	\$60 + \$9/person	Add HR tools, PTO, performance reviews
BambooHR	~\$6-9/person	Employee records, org chart, lifecycle mgmt
QuickBooks Essentials	\$75/mo	Multi-user, bill tracking

\$500K+ Revenue — project profitability becomes critical

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Productive	\$24-32/user	Project profitability, utilization, rate cards
QuickBooks Plus	\$115/mo	Project costing, class tracking
Gusto + BambooHR	Keep	Payroll and HR — stable

30-50 Employees — IT and HR converge

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Rippling	~\$20-30/person	Replaces Gusto + BambooHR — HR + IT unified
QuickBooks Advanced	\$340/mo	Full analytics, payroll bundle, AI features
Productive	Keep	Project profitability — permanent

Monthly Cost by Stage

STAGE	MONTHLY COST	TOOLS ACTIVE
Today	\$0/mo	QB Free + Stripe + ClickUp
3+ clients	~\$55/mo	+ QB Simple Start + FreshBooks
First hire	~\$110/mo	+ Gusto
5 employees	~\$175/mo	+ BambooHR
10 employees	~\$450/mo	+ Productive + QB upgrade
20 employees	~\$900/mo	Rippling + QB Advanced + Productive
50 employees	~\$2,500/mo	Full enterprise stack

Louisiana Compliance Milestones

These are the legal thresholds that trigger new obligations as Revital Productions grows. Each milestone requires action — your tools should be in place before you hit each one.

MILESTONE	THRESHOLD	WHAT IT TRIGGERS	TOOL THAT HANDLES IT
1099 filing	\$600+/contractor (2025), \$2,000+ (2026)	File 1099-NEC by Feb 2	QuickBooks
Employer account	\$50K+ annual payroll	Register with Louisiana Workforce Commission	Gusto (handles registration)
Title VII	15+ employees	Anti-discrimination law applies	BambooHR (policy tracking)
COBRA	20+ employees	Must offer health continuation coverage	Gusto + benefits broker
FMLA	50+ employees	Family & Medical Leave Act applies	Rippling (FMLA tracking built in)
ACA	50+ employees	Must offer health insurance or pay penalty	Rippling + benefits broker

Immediate Action Items

Do This Week

- Set up QuickBooks Free at quickbooks.intuit.com/online/free — takes 10 minutes
- Connect your business bank account to QuickBooks
- Connect Stripe to QuickBooks (Settings > Integrations > Stripe)
- Log all existing clients as contacts in QuickBooks

Do at 3+ Clients

- Upgrade QuickBooks to Simple Start (\$38/mo) — skip free trial to get 50% off 3 months
- Add FreshBooks Lite (\$17/mo) for client-facing invoices and retainer tracking
- Set up recurring payment links in Stripe for monthly retainer clients

Do Before First Hire

- Set up Gusto at gusto.com the week before your first W2 employee starts
- Complete Gusto + QuickBooks integration so payroll syncs automatically
- Set up employee handbook and onboarding checklist in BambooHR
- Open a Louisiana employer account with the Workforce Commission